

Locating the practice of scrolling through TikTok within the breakdown of 'normal' everyday life during the pandemic

Introduction: Why TikTok?

- Short video app; available internationally since around 2017; 1 billion users worldwide.
- Negative and patronising reporting on the app; image of it being an ultimate 'time wasting machine' (e.g. Odell 2019).
- Rise in popularity during pandemic as means to fight the 'lockdown boredom' whilst trapped at home (e.g. Kale 2020)
- Case to understand the consequences of 'addictive' media and practices such as scrolling on people's wellbeing.

Overview of the study

- Grounded in ethnographic tradition of audience studies focussed on the ritual and everyday contexts of media use (cf. Ang 1985, Hermes 1995, Lull 1990, Morley 1986, Radway 1984, ...).
- 6 months of digital ethnography on TikTok to gain contextual understanding (see Schellewald 2021).
- Series of semi-structured interviews over 1 year with 30 young adults based in UK (Summer 2020 to Summer 2021).

Everyday uses of TikTok

- Use of TikTok when the experiential continuity of everyday life is under threat, e.g. moments of tiredness, boredom, or lacking inspiration.
- Remediating prior routines and rituals of rest, break, and escape (commuting, going for walk, ...).
- Food metaphors used to describe TikTok; scrolling helps 'digest' they day whilst not being able to function as 'main course' of entertainment.

Locating TikTok in polymedia life

- Central feature of the app, For You Page, creates 'personalised structure of feeling' that enables escapist practices.
- Access to relatable and joyful content on the For You Page in a very flexible way because of TikTok's mobility.
- Many different apps that enable scrolling? Why TikTok? New app that is integrated into polymedia environments as dedicated 'escape site'.

Conceptualising mindless scrollers

- In debates mindless scrolling often approached as a symptom of addictive media and not something that is actively pursued by people.
- People struggled with addictive nature of TikTok but also developed ways of negotiating it.
- For some mindless scrolling only meaningful during lockdown, for others normal escapist practices and everyday routine.

Thanks!

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